

Psalms 106

We Have Sinned With Our Fathers

We have sinned with our fathers, we have committed iniquity, we have done wickedly
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Praise ye the LORD. O give thanks unto the LORD; for he is good: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 2 Who can utter the mighty acts of the LORD? who can shew forth all his praise?
- 3 Blessed are they that keep judgment, and he that doeth righteousness at all times.
- 4 Remember me, O LORD, with the favour that thou bearest unto thy people: O visit me with thy salvation;
- 5 That I may see the good of thy chosen, that I may rejoice in the gladness of thy nation, that I may glory with thine inheritance.
- 6 We have sinned with our fathers, we have committed iniquity, we have done wickedly.
- 7 Our fathers understood not thy wonders in Egypt; they remembered not the multitude of thy mercies; but provoked him at the sea, even at the Red sea.
- 8 Nevertheless he saved them for his name's sake, that he might make his mighty power to be known.
- 9 He rebuked the Red sea also, and it was dried up: so he led them through the depths, as through the wilderness.
- 10 And he saved them from the hand of him that hated them, and redeemed them from the hand of the enemy.
- 11 And the waters covered their enemies: there was not one of them left.
- 12 Then believed they his words; they sang his praise.
- 13 They soon forgot his works; they waited not for his counsel:
- 14 But lusted exceedingly in the wilderness, and tempted God in the desert.
- 15 And he gave them their request; but sent leanness into their soul.
- 16 They envied Moses also in the camp, and Aaron the saint of the LORD.
- 17 The earth opened and swallowed up Dathan, and covered the company of Abiram.
- 18 And a fire was kindled in their company; the flame burned up the wicked.
- 19 They made a calf in Horeb, and worshipped the molten image.
- 20 Thus they changed their glory into the similitude of an ox that eateth grass.
- 21 They forgot God their saviour, which had done great things in Egypt;
- 22 Wondrous works in the land of Ham, and terrible things by the Red sea.
- 23 Therefore he said that he would destroy them, had not Moses his chosen stood before him in the breach, to turn away his wrath, lest he should destroy them.
- 24 Yea, they despised the pleasant land, they believed not his word:
- 25 But murmured in their tents, and hearkened not unto the voice of the LORD.
- 26 Therefore he lifted up his hand against them, to overthrow them in the wilderness:
- 27 To overthrow their seed also among the nations, and to scatter them in the lands.
- 28 They joined themselves also unto Baal-peor, and ate the sacrifices of the dead.
- 29 Thus they provoked him to anger with their inventions: and the plague brake in upon them.
- 30 Then stood up Phinehas, and executed judgment: and so the plague was stayed.
- 31 And that was counted unto him for righteousness unto all generations for evermore.
- 32 They angered him also at the waters of strife, so that it went ill with Moses for their sakes:
- 33 Because they provoked his spirit, so that he spake unadvisedly with his lips.
- 34 They did not destroy the nations, concerning whom the LORD commanded them:
- 35 But were mingled among the heathen, and learned their works.
- 36 And they served their idols: which were a snare unto them.
- 37 Yea, they sacrificed their sons and their daughters unto devils,
- 38 And shed innocent blood, even the blood of their sons and of their daughters, whom they sacrificed unto the idols of Canaan: and the land was polluted with blood.
- 39 Thus were they defiled with their own works, and went a whoring with their own inventions.

40 *Therefore was the wrath of the LORD kindled against his people, insomuch that he abhorred his own inheritance.*
41 *And he gave them into the hand of the heathen; and they that hated them ruled over them.*
42 *Their enemies also oppressed them, and they were brought into subjection under their hand.*
43 *Many times did he deliver them; but they provoked him with their counsel, and were brought low for their iniquity.*
44 *Nevertheless he regarded their affliction, when he heard their cry:*
45 *And he remembered for them his covenant, and repented according to the multitude of his mercies.*
46 *He made them also to be pitied of all those that carried them captives.*
47 *Save us, O LORD our God, and gather us from among the heathen, to give thanks unto thy holy name, and to triumph in thy praise.*
48 *Blessed be the Lord God of Israel from everlasting to everlasting: and let all the people say, Amen. Praise ye the LORD.*

2 • CONTEXT

Where Psalm 105 celebrated Israel's history purely as evidence of God's faithfulness, Psalm 106 retells much of the same history as a sustained confession of the nation's repeated unfaithfulness—idolatry, rebellion, ingratitude—met again and again by God's patient mercy. Henry reads the two psalms as deliberately paired: gratitude for God's faithfulness and honest confession of persistent failure belong together, and neither is complete without the other. MacArthur-style notes highlight the recurring cycle of sin, judgment, cry for help, and deliverance as a pattern meant to instruct, not merely inform.

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-5

The psalm opens in praise—give thanks, for His mercy endures forever—before turning immediately to petition: remember me, Lord, with the favor You show Your people, visit me with Your salvation, that I may see the good of Your chosen and rejoice with Your inheritance. Personal hope is tied directly to the nation's larger story.

Verse 6-12

Confession begins at once: we have sinned with our fathers, committed iniquity, done wickedly. The fathers' failure at the Red Sea is recalled specifically—they understood not God's wonders in Egypt, provoked Him at the sea—yet God saved them anyway for His own name's sake, rebuking the sea so it dried up, leading them through as through a wilderness, saving them from the hand of the enemy. Remarkably, that generation did briefly believe His words and sing His praise, showing even their faith was real, if short-lived.

Verse 13-15

Just as quickly, they forgot His works and did not wait for His counsel, lusting exceedingly in the wilderness and testing God in the desert. He granted their request, but sent leanness into their souls along with it—a warning that getting what one demands is not always evidence of blessing.

Verse 16-23

Rebellion escalates: envy of Moses and Aaron, the earth opening to swallow Dathan and cover Abiram's company, fire consuming the wicked among them. The making of the golden calf at Horeb is recounted starkly—glory exchanged for the likeness of an ox that eats grass—leading God to plan their destruction, had Moses not stood in the breach as an intercessor to turn away His wrath.

Verse 24-27

Further rebellion follows in the wilderness: the pleasant land despised, God's word not believed, murmuring in their tents instead of obedience. God's response was to swear that generation would not enter the land, their descendants scattered among the nations—consequences extending beyond the immediate offenders.

Verse 28-33

Idolatry at Baal-peor and the plague that followed are recalled, along with Phinehas's decisive intervention, which stayed the plague and was counted to him as righteousness for all generations. Even Moses himself is shown provoked to sin at the waters of strife, speaking unadvisedly under pressure—no one, however faithful, is presented as immune to failure.

Verse 34-39

The deepest failure follows entry into the land itself: the nations were not destroyed as commanded, but mingled with instead, learning their practices, serving their idols, even sacrificing sons and daughters to false gods and shedding innocent blood, polluting the land—idolatry's cost measured in human lives, not merely broken ritual.

Verse 40-48

God's resulting anger and Israel's subsequent oppression under enemy nations is described, along with a repeating cycle: deliverance given, provocation returning, humbling under iniquity, yet God's compassion moved again and again by their cry, remembering His covenant and relenting according to His abundant mercy. The psalm closes with direct petition—save us, gather

us from among the nations, that we may give thanks—and a doxology: blessed be the Lord God of Israel from everlasting to everlasting, let all the people say, Amen. Praise the Lord.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Honest national and personal history includes repeated failure—forgetfulness, rebellion, idolatry with real human cost—and Scripture does not soften this record to protect anyone's reputation, including Moses'. Yet the psalm's dominant note is not despair but God's compassion, moved again and again by simple cries for help, remembering His covenant even when His people had given Him every reason to abandon it.

Application for life today.

Let this psalm's unflinching honesty about repeated failure—even among the most faithful, like Moses—give you permission to confess a recurring pattern of sin specifically rather than vaguely. Notice that the cycle here breaks not through the people's improvement but through God's remembered covenant and compassion in response to their cry; let that reshape how you seek restoration after repeated failure in your own life. Consider who, like Phinehas or Moses in the breach, might need your own decisive intervention on their behalf right now.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What recurring pattern of failure in your own life does this psalm's honest confession (vv. 6, 13, 21, 24) give you permission to name specifically rather than vaguely?

2. How does the cycle of sin, judgment, cry for help, and God's remembered compassion (vv. 40–46) reshape your expectations for how restoration actually happens?

3. Where might you need to intervene decisively on someone else's behalf, as Moses and Phinehas did (vv. 23, 30), rather than merely observing their struggle?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).